DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 1

Virtual assistant (including personal and executive assistants)

Profession 1 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

A virtual assistant (VA) supports a client remotely with email, calendar, research, documents, scheduling and admin tasks. Personal and executive assistants do similar work with more responsibility for the person they support.

What professionals do every day

Triages email, manages calendars, books meetings, researches, updates CRMs and spreadsheets, prepares documents, and follows up on tasks.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Owners and managers lose hours each week on admin. A VA takes those hours back, usually for a fixed monthly package.

- Missed emails and double bookings.
- Tasks with no owner or deadline.
- Research done again and again.

Skills you need

- Email and calendar management.
- Research and organised notes.
- Task tracking.
- Confidential handling of information.
- Clear written updates.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
Google Workspace	Mail, calendar, documents	Free personal account	Paid business plans	workspace.google.com
Microsoft 365	Outlook, Excel, Word, Teams	Free web apps	Paid plans	www.microsoft.com/microsoft-365
Trello	Task boards	Free tier	Paid plans	trello.com
Notion	Notes and wikis	Free tier	Paid plans	www.notion.so

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish

Beginner	Set up a shared inbox folder structure.
Intermediate	Manage a calendar with buffers and time zones.
Advanced	Run one weekly task board for a client.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Calendar and inbox management for a founder.
- **Intermediate:** Research pack for a monthly meeting.
- **Advanced:** Client onboarding for a firm.

Client-ready portfolio project

A one-week VA package for a fictional founder: inbox triage rules, a calendar with buffers, a task board and a Friday summary.

Worked example

Worked example. Each morning the VA sorts email into 'reply today', 'reply this week' and 'file', drafts replies for approval and books the meetings the founder accepts.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Inbox triage rules

Business problem: A founder receives 80 emails a day and misses important ones.

Steps

1. Define four categories: act today, delegate, file, ignore.
2. Write one rule for each category with an example.
3. Test the rules on a sample of 20 emails.
4. Record the accuracy of the triage.

Expected output: Rules and a triage accuracy result.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

Clear categories with examples make triage consistent. A sample test shows where the rules fail, so they can be adjusted before daily use.

Common mistakes

- Accepting meetings without checking the calendar.
- Unclear authority to reply on the client's behalf.
- No written daily summary.
- Sharing confidential material in the wrong channel.

Freelancing opportunities

- Monthly VA packages for founders and small firms.
- Project support for agencies.
- Briefs on freelance marketplaces: 'virtual assistant', 'executive assistant', 'admin support'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- Google Workspace Admin Help
- Microsoft 365 help

Part of **Master Freelancing: Admin and Business Support**. **Back to the chapter list on skillnavora.in** · **Open the full textbook**. Official links in this chapter were not checked live; confirm before relying on them.